

Smooth

A smooth, clean optical-style compressor with one main knob.



Overview

Smooth is a clean compressor in the spirit of the classic one-knob software compressors. Turn COMPRESS up for more compression and set OUTPUT to taste: that is most of the job.

Its timing is optical-style: the release lets go quickly at first, then more slowly, and the longer the compression has been held, the slower it recovers. The detector ignores the deep lows, so the bass doesn't make it pump, and the gain is applied evenly across the spectrum, so the top end - the air - stays intact. A gentle valve-style colour stage follows the compressor.

Reach for it for

- Smoothing vocals without dulling them
- Gentle levelling on bass, acoustic guitar and keys
- Easy glue on a mix or group bus
- Hard, fast limiting of peaks (LIMIT)
- Parallel compression with BLEND

Controls

Main panel

COMPRESS	The main knob, 0 - 10 (3 by default). It lowers the threshold from 0 to -30 dB: turn it up for more compression.
BLEND	Dry / compressed mix, 0 - 100%, for parallel compression. 100% is fully compressed.
Gain reduction meter	The needle shows how much the compressor is turning the level down, 0 - 20 dB.
ATTACK	SLOW (25 ms), MEDIUM (8 ms, default) or FAST (1.5 ms). Click a label to pick it, or click the knob to step through. With LIMIT on, the attack is twice as fast.
LIMIT	Off: a soft, wide-knee 3:1 curve - transparent. On: a hard 20:1 curve with a faster attack, for catching peaks.
RELEASE	SLOW, MEDIUM (default) or FAST: the overall recovery speed. The first part of the reduction always lets go quickly; the rest takes longer, and longer still after heavy, sustained compression.
OUTPUT	Make-up gain, -12 to +24 dB.
LEVEL	The output level on ten lights, from -30 dBFS (green) to 0 dBFS (red).

Drift, input and output

DRIFT	The colour stage's drive and asymmetry wander slowly, independently on each side, 0 - 100% (50% is the standard amount, 100% twice that, 0% none). The wander also speeds up a little as you turn it up. Subtle: it moves the warmth, not the level.
IN TRIM	Input level before anything else, from -24 to +12 dB.
GUARD	Click the IN TRIM knob to switch it; its LED sits at the knob's upper right. On by default. Gently eases very hot sources down towards about -18 dBFS average and catches fast peaks above -6 dBFS, so loud sources never

	overdrive the plugin. It never boosts quiet sources. The LED glows brighter while it is working.
SAT	Band saturation on the way out: only the lows and highs are saturated (the mids stay clean), with a soft curve that loosens as the level rises.
OFF / CLIP / LIMIT	The final stage: nothing, a soft clipper at -0.3 dBFS (no latency), or a lookahead limiter (3 ms latency, compensated by REAPER). CLIP is on by default and flashes red when it clips.

Panel keys

S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

In REAPER's parameter list only

Drift amount / Drift speed	The standard drift that DRIFT scales: how far the colour stage wanders (25% by default) and how fast (0.02 - 2 Hz, 0.25 Hz by default).
Bias / Sat low band / Sat high band / Ceiling	The rest of the output stage: the saturation's even-harmonic bias, where its low and high bands start (40 - 400 Hz and 2 - 16 kHz) and the clip ceiling or limiter threshold.

Tips

- Turn COMPRESS up until the meter shows 3 - 6 dB on the loud parts, then bring OUTPUT up to match the bypassed level.
- SLOW attack lets the front of each note through for a punchier, more natural sound; FAST holds everything steadier.

- For parallel compression, set COMPRESS high with LIMIT on and pull BLEND down to 30 - 50%.
- Because the detector ignores the deep lows, Smooth works well on full mixes without the bass making everything duck.

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